

The "Unspoken Rules" for Getting Promoted

Gorick Ng | Big Think | YouTube search: "Harvard career coach unspoken rules getting promoted Big Think"

Name: _____ Period: _____ Date: _____

■ WHAT THIS VIDEO IS ABOUT

Gorick Ng is a career advisor at Harvard and bestselling author who grew up as the son of a working-class single mother. He was told his whole life that the key to getting ahead was to put his head down and let his hard work speak for itself. When he entered professional spaces, he discovered that was only half the equation. In this video, he breaks down the "unspoken rules" that separate employees who get promoted from those who get overlooked — and why nobody tells you these rules out loud.

Review Questions — Answer as You Watch or Immediately After

Answer in the space provided. Complete sentences are required.

Question 1 — The Myth of Hard Work

Ng was told his whole life that putting his head down and working hard was enough to get ahead. What did he discover when he actually entered the workforce — and what was the critical thing he was missing?

Question 2 — Insiders vs. Outsiders

Ng describes two types of workers: insiders and outsiders. What is the difference between them, and why does being an outsider put someone at a disadvantage even if their work is just as good?

Question 3 — The Why, What, How, By When Framework

Ng says top performers clarify four things every time they receive a task: Why, What, How, and By When. Pick one of these four and explain specifically why most people skip it — and what goes wrong when they do.

Question 4 — Being Useful vs. Being Impactful

Ng makes a distinction between being "useful" and being "impactful." In your own words, what is the difference? Give one example of what being impactful might look like in a job in your career pathway.



Read the scenario carefully. Respond in complete sentences. One-sentence answers will not receive full credit.

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THE SITUATION

Deja and Marcus both started at the same company on the same day in the same role. After one year, Marcus gets promoted. Deja does not. By every measurable standard, Deja outperforms Marcus — her reports are cleaner, she finishes faster, and she makes fewer errors. But Marcus asks clarifying questions before starting every assignment, volunteers for projects outside his job description, builds relationships with people across departments, and regularly checks in with his supervisor to make sure his work is aligned with what the team actually needs. Deja puts her head down, does excellent work, and waits to be recognized.

Using Ng's framework from the video, explain why Marcus got promoted and Deja did not. Is this fair? What specific "unspoken rules" was Marcus following that Deja was not? And what would you tell Deja if she came to you frustrated about being passed over? Respond in at least 4 complete sentences.

